The CareLeaders

Programme brochure

Work experience Aged 16 to 18

Care to Work



A work experience programme for care experienced young people aged 16 to 18, commissioned by councils as corporate parents.

Contents



Work experience

Care to Work

03 Why we created it

04 What it is

05 Who it is for

06 How it works

07 Step by step

08 The timeline

09 Training the hosts

10 What changes, and what you keep

11 Case study: Suffolk

12 In their words

13 Your facilitator

14 Reaching young people

15 Getting started

Why we created it

Care leavers are more than twice as likely to be out of work, education or training.

Your council has a duty to prepare these young people for adult life. It is also one of the largest employers in your area. Those two facts rarely meet.

Care to Work joins them, starting with work experience: one or two day placements in your teams and with local employers, chosen by young people themselves. The gap is not ambition. It is a first chance, and an adult at work who understands where a young person has come from.

That's why we created Care to Work.

Care to Work | Work experience

The gap

40%

of care leavers aged 19 to 21 in England are not in education, employment or training.

15%

is the estimate for all young people the same age.

Source: Department for Education, Children looked after in England including adoptions, reporting year 2025 (year ending 31 March 2025). The 15% comes from the Labour Force Survey.

What it is

An 11-month work experience programme that starts inside your council. We train mentors and personal advisers first, then open placements in your teams and with local employers. We support your council and community to give care leavers their first taste of work.

A set-up
Three design labs with your young people, months 1 to 3

Your own brand
Named and signed off by your young people

Work experience
10 or more placements for 16 to 18 year olds

Trained mentors
One for every placement, trained with your PAs

The Mentors Toolkit
A workbook and six online modules

Support that lasts
Three months of support after a placement



Who this programme is for

For	Councils, as corporate parents and as large local employers
Young people	Care experienced, aged 16 to 18
Trained first	Personal advisers (PAs) and mentors
Led by	A named project lead and executive sponsor in your council

What it sets out to do

Care leavers get a first chance at work.

Three objectives, for every council we work with. Everyone who supports a young person is trained first, so the placement works for them from day one.

Opportunities

Real first chances, starting with your council

One or two day placements in your teams and with local employers.

A trained mentor for every placement.

A menu of opportunities young people choose from with their PA.

Support

The adults around them, trained before day one

PAs and mentors trained before any young person starts.

Young people choose their placement with their PA.

Three months of mentor and PA support after a placement.

Legacy

A programme your council owns

A brand named by your young people, and a communications plan.

The Mentors Toolkit and trained mentors, so your teams can run the next cohort.

A final report on what worked, and what to do next.

What young people get



A first chance they chose, and a CV with something on it



A trained mentor on the other side of it



Their own PA alongside them at every step



A placement they picked from the menu



A route on to The Care Leaders Fellowship

How the programme works, in three steps.

Every council has its own services, employers and young people, so we don't sell an off-the-shelf scheme. It runs for 11 months and starts with a set-up built with your young people.

1

We set it up together

Months 1 to 3. Three design labs with your young people: what good support looks like, a name and brand they choose, and sign-off. We build your communications plan and governance alongside them.

→

2

We find the placements

Employers pledge a placement and a mentor each, and hosts plan placements young people can choose from. 10 or more placements for 16 to 18 year olds.

→

3

We prepare the hosts, then go live

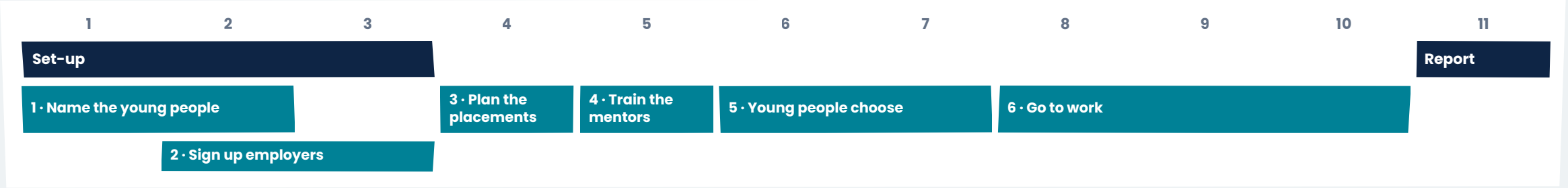
Mentors and PAs are trained first. Then a six-week campaign calls care leavers to choose a placement, and we support every young person through it.

Want jobs too? Our apprenticeships and jobs strand, for 18 to 25 year olds, runs alongside on the same set-up. A young person can go from work experience at 17 to a job at 18, with the same PA.

Aged 16 to 18

Work experience, step by step.

Every young person gets a first taste of work they chose, with a mentor in their corner.



1 — Months 1 to 2

Name the young people

Each PA names a care leaver and asks what they want from work.

→

2 — Months 2 to 3

Sign up employers

At an employers event, each pledges a placement and a mentor. Checks agreed.

→

3 — Month 4

Plan the placements

Hosts plan each placement. They go on a menu young people choose from.

→

4 — Month 5

Train the mentors

A training day with your PAs, then six online modules.

→

5 — Months 6 to 7

Young people choose

A six-week campaign. Each young person picks from the menu with their PA.

→

6 — Months 8 to 10

Go to work

One or two day placements, then three months of mentor and PA support.

Your part

- Release your PAs
- Your safeguarding lead signs off the checks
- Host placements in your own teams

10+ placements, each with a trained mentor. A target we work towards with you.

At a glance

The programme in numbers.

11 **Months**
From set-up to handover

3 **Design labs**
With your young people, in months 1 to 3

6 **Steps**
One simple route

10+ **Placements**
For 16 to 18 year olds

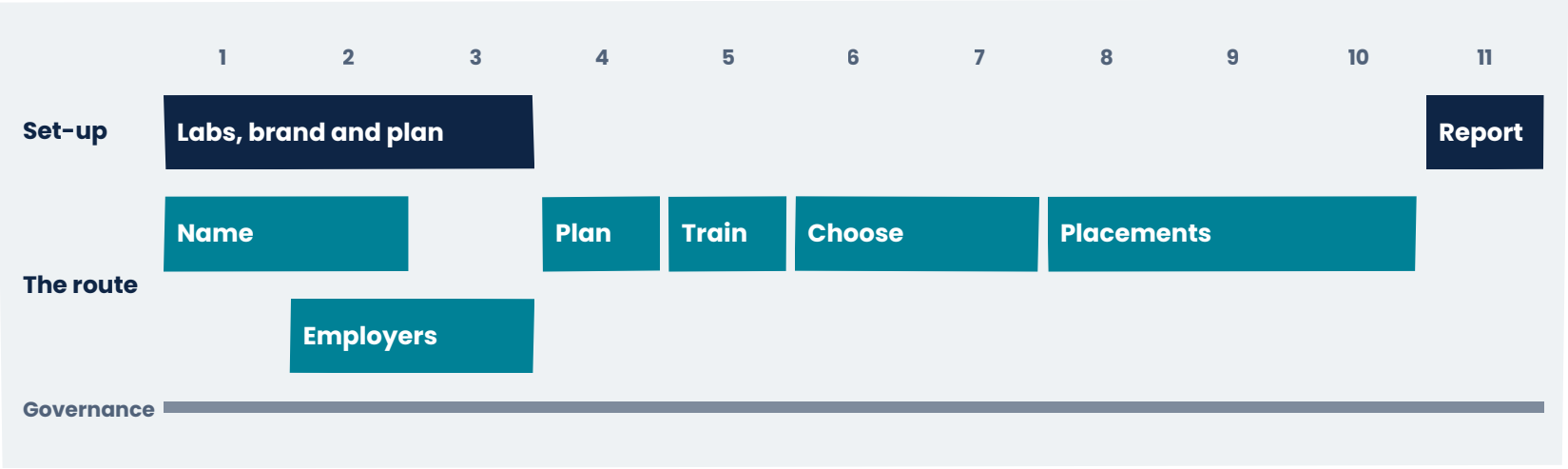
1 **Trained mentor**
For every placement

3 **Months**
Of support after a placement

The timeline

Eleven months to handover.

The route runs on an 11-month clock, from set-up to handover. Exact dates are agreed with you at the start.



Month 3
Brand signed off. Employers have pledged placements and mentors.

Month 5
Mentors and PAs trained.

Month 8
Placements begin.

Month 11
Final report presented in person, and handover.

Placements run in months 8 to 10, so every young person has three months of mentor and PA support before handover.

Every mentor trained before day one.

Mentors learn our Access to Opportunity framework: apply from the menu, meet your mentor, go to work experience. Their toolkit stays with them online, so the next mentor in your council can learn it too.

What mentors get

Access to Opportunity
Our three-step framework for every mentor.

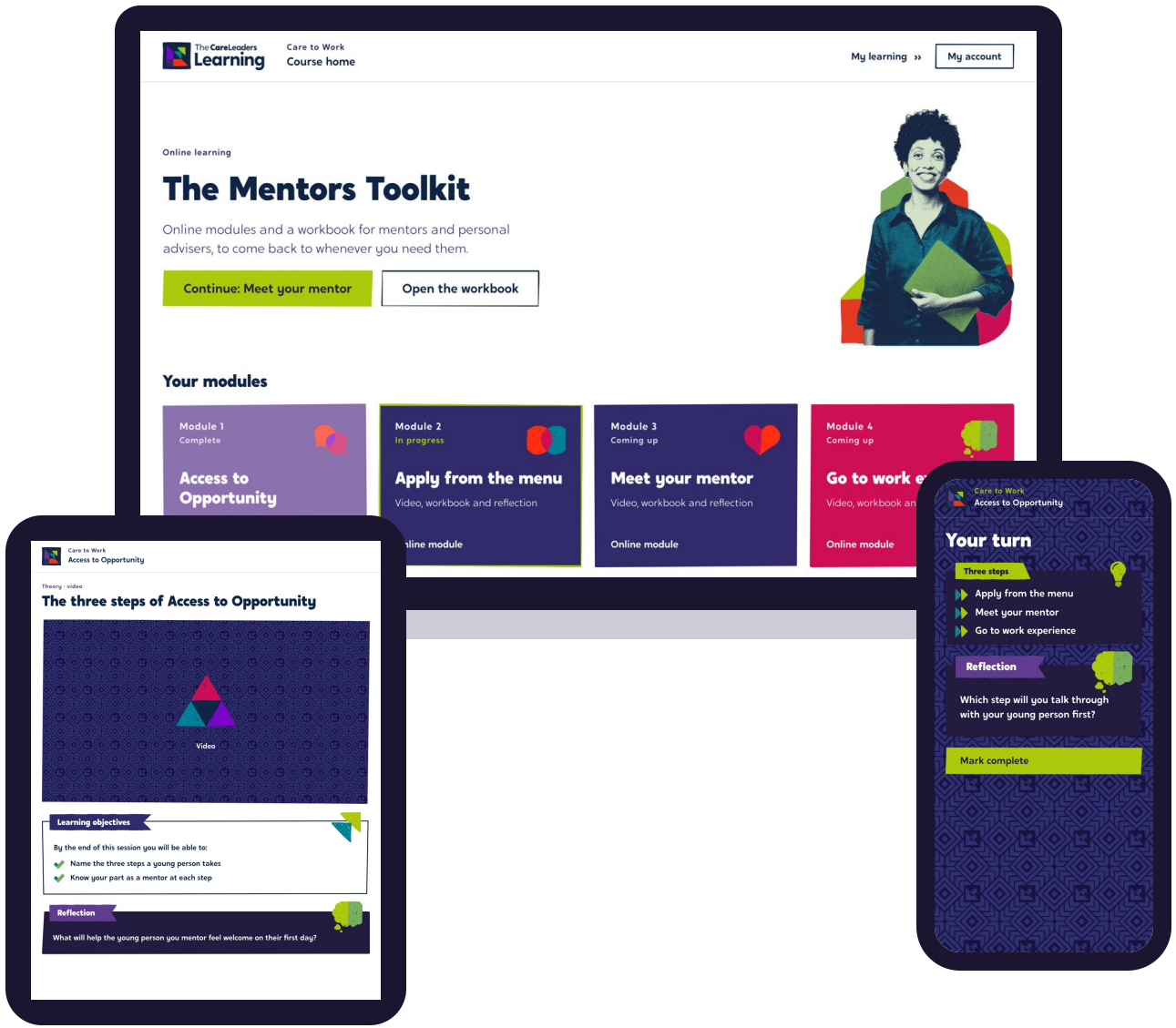
The Mentors Toolkit
A training day, a workbook and six online modules.

PAs trained alongside
With mentors, not separately.

The placement template
Hosts plan every placement on it.

Online, your way
A SCORM file for your system, or The Care Leaders Online.

Support after training
Three mentor and PA sessions over three months.



What changes

A first taste of work, starting with your council.

01 **For young people.** A first chance they chose, and a CV with something on it, with a trained mentor on the other side of it.

02 **For mentors.** Mentors across your council and your area who know what care experience means, and how to host well.

03 **For your council.** Corporate parenting you can count, a brand and a toolkit you reuse every year, and evidence that came from young people.

10+

Work experience placements, each with a trained mentor

a target we work towards with you

One final report, presented in person: who took part, what young people, hosts and your teams told us, what worked, and your next phase.

What you keep

Nothing we build stays ours.

With the mentors and PAs we train, your teams can run the next cohort without us.

- Your local brand, with guidelines, templates and a Canva workspace
- The communications plan, to reach young people, hosts and employers every year
- The final report: who took part, what everyone told us, and what to do next
- The menu of opportunities, and the placement template hosts fill in
- The Mentors Toolkit: training, a workbook and six online modules

Case study

Suffolk County Council

Suffolk County Council

November 2022 to October 2024. Programme design, co-design, coaching and film.

60+ people at the employer launch

5 ring-fenced council apprenticeships agreed in the first year

6 care leavers in council apprenticeships, 4 completed or on track

Up to 40 young people gained qualifications through the Skills Academy

From corporate parenting to community parenting.

Care leavers in Suffolk had a corporate parent in the council, but not many of the things a parent gives you: a first job, a contact who knows someone, a place to learn how work works. The council wanted to change that from the inside, starting with its own jobs. Care to Work is built on what we learned there.

Listen

A two-day stakeholder review across seven groups, from care leavers to managers and HR. Goodwill everywhere, routes into work almost nowhere.

Design

A six-phase programme: a brand co-designed with young people, a comms strategy, induction and supervisor training, and a project board.

Open doors

An Innovation Board of local business owners and an employer event. Placements went live in Waste, Fire and Rescue, and Home First.

Keep it going

Coaching, apprentice onboarding and sustainability planning, then films with care leavers telling their own stories.

What changed

The employer launch drew over 60 people, and the council's own report recorded "an overwhelming number of opportunities" for young people. The NHS offered a six-week course for 30 care experienced people.

pwc

Also: PwC. In September 2024, 30 care leavers from Kent, West Sussex, East Sussex and Suffolk spent a day at PwC's London office, through our councils and networks.

In their words

They have supported us to create a sustainable programme which offers ring-fenced work opportunities, including apprenticeships to our care leavers, every year.

Matthew Cooke, Virtual School Head, Suffolk County Council
On the Suffolk employment programme, 2023





Luke Rodgers BEM
Founder and CEO, The Care Leaders

Your facilitator

From care leaver to care leader.

Luke went into care at 10. At 15 he was living in a bed and breakfast, and at 18 in a caravan. He gave his first keynote at 19 and has spent his career since inside children's services, as a consultant, trainer, board member and national engagement lead.

He has built routes into work with councils and employers. With Suffolk County Council he designed a programme that gave care leavers council work experience and ring-fenced apprenticeships, with placements in Waste, Fire and Rescue and Home First, and an employer launch that drew over 60 people.

He worked with PwC to open its New World, New Skills days to care leavers, and leads The Care Leaders' employment and pathways work with councils.

He founded The Care Leaders in 2017, and it has since worked with 36 local authorities and national bodies, including the Department for Education and the NHS. He knows what an employer needs before they say yes, and what a young person needs to stay in work once they start.

- **Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award**
  iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026
- **British Empire Medal**
  2018, for commitment to children and families
- **Knowledge Equity Fellow**
  Saïd Business School, University of Oxford, 2020 to 2021
- **Social Entrepreneur Fellow**
  School for Social Entrepreneurs, 2015 to 2017

A campaign your young people put their name to.

Through the set-up and the campaign, we give your council everything it needs to reach care leavers, hosts and employers, under a brand your young people choose.

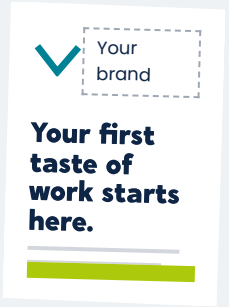
How we help young people apply and take part

- Every PA names a care leaver at the start, so the programme starts with real young people.
- Your young people name the brand, so the campaign sounds like them.
- A six-week campaign calls care leavers to apply, through their PAs.
- Young people choose from the menu of opportunities with their PA.
- Mentors and PAs stay with each young person for three months after their placement.

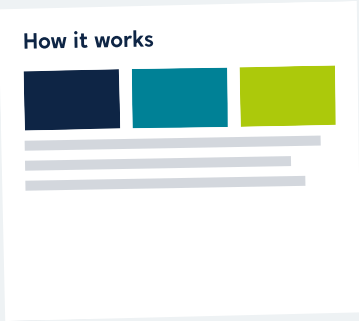
What we build with you



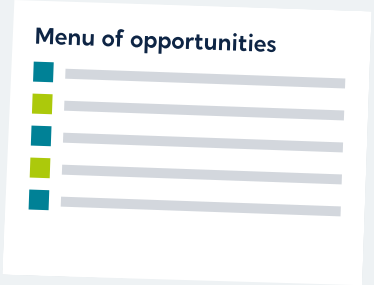
Brand guidelines
Named by your young people



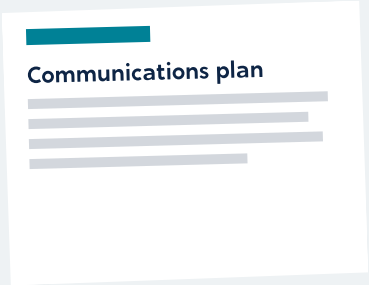
Campaign posters
For the six-week campaign



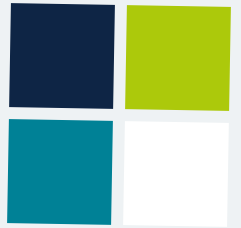
How it works
For care leavers and PAs



Menu of opportunities
What young people choose from



Communications plan
For young people, hosts and employers



Canva workspace
Templates your teams can edit

The CareLeaders

Care to Work

Work experience

Getting started

Four steps to your first cohort.

1 **Get in touch**

Email us, or scan the QR code and fill in our short form about your council.

2 **Have an initial call**

We reply within 3 working days to book a call about your young people, your employers and your dates.

3 **We provide a quote**

A clear price, and what is included.

4 **We set it up with you**

Your young people are in the first design lab within weeks.

hello@thecareleaders.com

Scan to tell us about your council

A five-minute form that gives us what we need for our first call.

What we need from you

- A named project lead and an executive sponsor
- PAs released for the kick-off and the training
- Checks, insurance, rooms and data, throughout
- Your safeguarding lead signs off the checks and the menu
- Placements hosted in some of your own teams
- Mentors released for the training

Commissioned by your council as corporate parent. Contact us for a price.

iese Awards GOLD Winner 2026 The Public Sector Transformation Awards

Children & Young People Now Awards 2023 Winner

Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award, iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026.
Children & Young People Now Workforce Development Award 2023.

The Care Leaders Ltd, company number 10782615